Design Methods

Amy J. Ko, 2nd edition

Amy J. Ko's Design Methods describes design as a way of understanding problems, exploring possibilities, and learning through making and evaluation. Design decisions shape what people can do and whose needs receive attention. The book emphasizes iteration: new evidence can change both a proposed solution and our understanding of the problem.

Understanding a problem begins with identifying the people involved and learning about their experiences. Interviews, observation, and other research can reveal goals, barriers, and differences between people. Designers synthesize these insights into problem statements, personas, and scenarios. These representations should be grounded in evidence rather than assumptions about an average user.

Creativity involves generating alternatives and making ideas visible so they can be compared and questioned. A prototype then explores a specific uncertainty before more resources are committed. Its value lies in what it helps us learn. For interfaces, this includes the relationship between input, state, and feedback: people need to understand what actions are possible and what happened after they acted.

The book distinguishes three ways of evaluating a design. Critique examines choices and their rationale through dialogue. Empirical evaluation observes people using a design. Analytical evaluation uses principles or walkthroughs to predict likely difficulties. These approaches offer different kinds of evidence. A usable interaction alone does not establish whether a design is useful in someone's life.

For MS Data Viz, these ideas connect audience research, representation, interaction, and evaluation. A visualization should help particular people answer meaningful questions. Exploring alternatives and examining evidence can reveal whether it serves that purpose, while attention to participation, values, and power helps expose whose perspectives are missing.

Source: Amy J. Ko, *Design Methods*, 2nd edition.
faculty.washington.edu/ajko/books/design-methods/

The DVC career-panel case

DVC's first career panel provides a case for applying the reading. The project connects a possible attendee need to a panel format, a small prototype, critique, and evaluation. The choices are provisional design ideas; they are not findings from attendee research.

1. Whose needs should DVC's first career panel address?

Consider a specific group of attendees, the difficulty they face, and evidence that could support or challenge our assumptions.

2. Which panel format would best serve those needs?

Compare shared speaker questions, career stories, and anonymous audience questions. Explain a choice and consider whom it might leave out.

3. How could we tell whether the panel was useful?

Distinguish critique, empirical observation, and analytical evaluation. Consider what a successful question-form interaction can show, and what still requires evidence.

Supporting materials

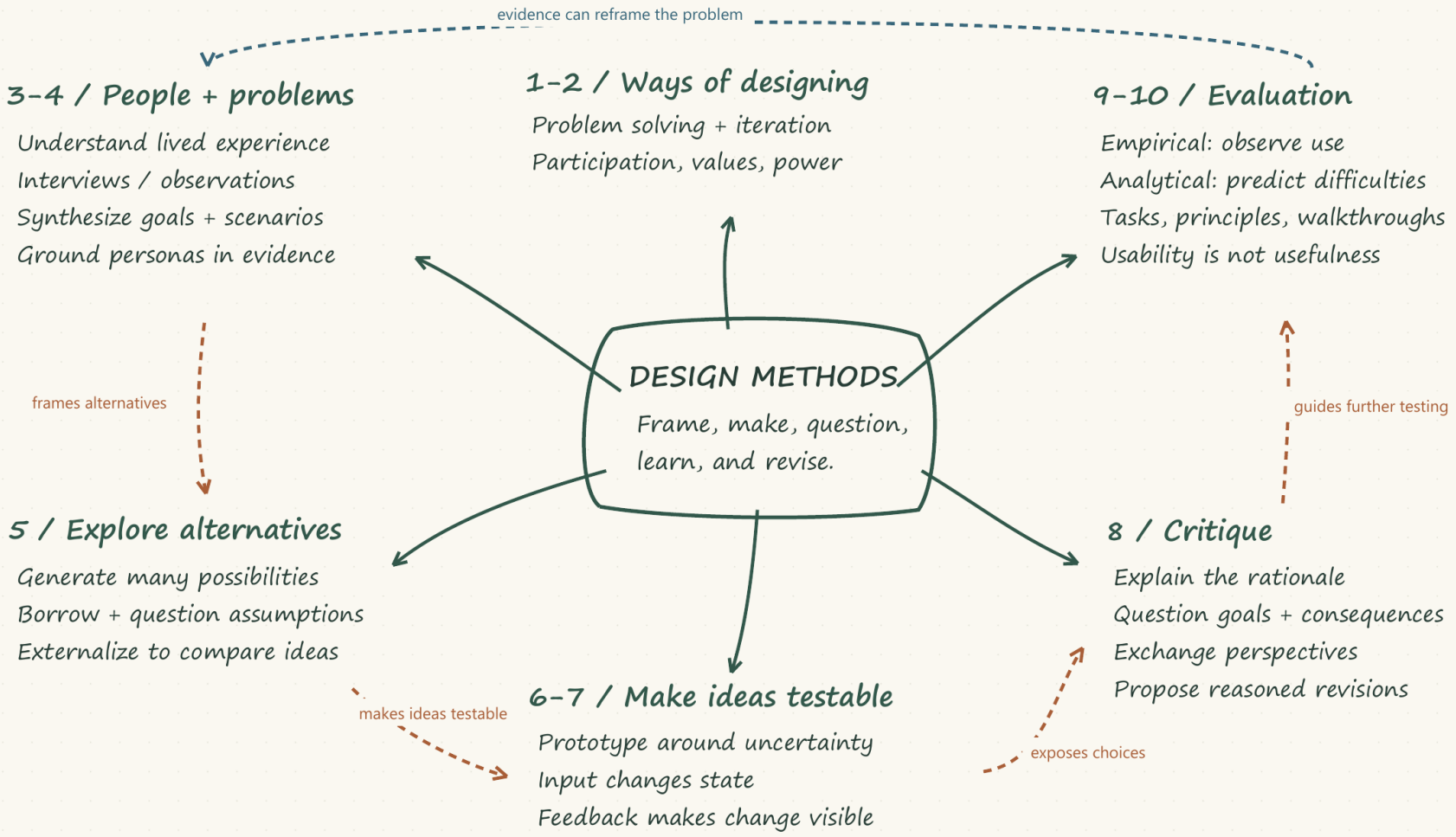
The interactive presentation places case activities beside concepts and chapter links from the book. Its question-form prototype illustrates input, state, and feedback: an attendee types a question, adds it to a practice queue, and receives confirmation. It is a local demonstration and sends nothing to DVC. The mind map on the next page organizes the main concepts and their relationships.

Interactive presentation | **Project repository**

Prepared with AI assistance for synthesis, wording, layout, and the digital-paper mind map.

Design Methods: learning through design

Amy J. Ko, 2nd ed. | Concept relationships across chapters 1-10



DVC connection: attendee need -> panel format -> question-form trial -> evidence -> revision

Solid branches organize concepts. Dashed arrows describe selected relationships; iteration can revisit any branch.

Digital-paper drawing with individually placed text and paths. AI-assisted synthesis; not a photographed hand drawing.

Source: Ko, Design Methods, chapters 1-10.